BIHARI COLLECTION

NO. 08



BIHAR ORIGIN

Besan ki Sabzi

Steamed Gram Flour Dumplings in Curry
A Pantry-Staple Dish Born of Scarcity

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Besan ki Sabzi

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Besan ki Sabzi

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

When the Vegetable Basket Runs Empty

Besan ki sabzi occupies a special place in Bihari home cooking as the dish many families turn to when fresh vegetables are scarce — during heavy monsoon flooding that once regularly cut off rural markets, or simply toward the end of a week when the vegetable basket has run low. Made from gram flour (besan) steamed into firm dumplings and simmered in a spiced gravy, it requires nothing more than pantry staples that any Bihari kitchen keeps on hand.

The technique bears a family resemblance to Rajasthan's gatte ki sabzi, another besan-dumpling curry from a historically dry, resource-conscious region, though Bihar's version carries its own distinct spicing, typically leaning on mustard oil and simpler, more direct seasoning rather than the more elaborate spice blends found in some Rajasthani cooking. Both dishes reflect a shared logic across different parts of India: gram flour, shelf-stable and protein-rich, became a reliable stand-in for vegetables whenever fresh produce wasn't available.

While born from necessity, besan ki sabzi has earned genuine appreciation on its own terms — the firm, slightly chewy texture of the steamed gram flour dumplings, soaking up a tangy, well-spiced gravy, offers something distinct enough from vegetable curries that many Bihari households make it by choice, not just when the pantry demands it.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

When the Vegetable Basket Runs Empty, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Historically a practical dish for periods of vegetable scarcity, including during monsoon flooding that once regularly disrupted rural market access in Bihar. Shares technical similarities with Rajasthan's gatte ki sabzi, reflecting a broader Indian tradition of using gram flour dumplings as a vegetable substitute in resource-conscious cooking. Requires only shelf-stable pantry ingredients, making it a genuinely practical dish for any kitchen, anywhere. Now enjoyed by choice as much as necessity, valued for its distinct texture within Bihari home cooking.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

15m	30m	4	Med
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Mixing bowl
- Steamer or a wide pot with a lid
- Kadai or wide pan, for the gravy
- Sharp knife, for cutting the dumplings

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Besan ki sabzi keeps refrigerated for up to 3 days. If you have leftover uncooked dumpling logs, they can be steamed and cut fresh, then added to reheated gravy for the best texture, as the dumplings can soften considerably after extended storage in the sauce.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the besan dumplings

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Besan (gram flour)	1½ cups	180 g	1½ katori
Ajwain (carom seeds)	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Turmeric powder	¼ tsp	1 g	¼ chammach
Red chili powder	¼ tsp	1 g	¼ chammach
Mustard oil	2 tbsp	30 ml	2 chammach
Salt	½ tsp	3 g	to taste
Water, as needed	3–4 tbsp	45–60 ml	3–4 chammach

For the gravy

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Mustard oil	3 tbsp	45 ml	3 chammach
Cumin seeds	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Onion, finely chopped	1 medium	100 g	1 medium
Ginger-garlic paste	1 tbsp	15 g	1 chammach
Tomato, pureed	2 medium	200 g	2 medium
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Coriander powder	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

For the gravy (cont.)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Red chili powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Water	2 cups	480 ml	2 katori
Salt	to taste	to taste	to taste
Fresh coriander, chopped, for garnish	2 tbsp	8 g	2 tbsp

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Besan is widely available at Indian grocers and in the gluten-free aisle of many general supermarkets. This dish requires no specialty ingredients beyond besan itself, making it one of the most universally accessible recipes in this collection — genuinely practical for cooks anywhere without access to Indian specialty vegetables.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Making the Besan Dumplings

01 MAKE THE DOUGH

Combine the besan, ajwain, turmeric, chili powder, mustard oil, and salt in a bowl. Gradually add water, kneading to a firm, smooth dough — similar in consistency to a stiff bread dough.

02 SHAPE INTO LOGS

Divide the dough into 3–4 portions and roll each into a thin log, about ¾ inch / 2 cm thick.



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Making the Besan Dumplings, continued

03 STEAM UNTIL FIRM

Steam the logs for 15–18 minutes, until firm and cooked through — test by inserting a knife, which should come out clean.

Chef tip. the dumplings should feel firm and slightly springy when pressed — undercooked dumplings will fall apart in the gravy later.

04 COOL AND SLICE

Let the steamed logs cool for a few minutes, then slice into rounds or small pieces, about ½ inch / 1 cm thick.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The dumpling logs should be firm all the way through with no soft, doughy center when sliced — if uncertain, steam for a few extra minutes before proceeding.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Gravy

05 SAUTÉ THE ONIONS

Heat mustard oil in a kadai and add the cumin seeds, letting them sizzle. Add the chopped onion and sauté until golden, about 7–8 minutes.

06 ADD AROMATICS AND TOMATO

Stir in the ginger-garlic paste, cooking until fragrant, then add the tomato puree, turmeric, coriander powder, and chili powder. Simmer for 8–10 minutes, until thickened and the oil separates slightly.



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Building the Gravy, continued

07 ADD WATER AND THE DUMPLINGS

Pour in the water and salt, bring to a simmer, then gently add the sliced dumplings. Simmer for 8–10 minutes, allowing the dumplings to absorb some of the gravy's flavor while holding their shape.

Texture indicator. the dumplings should be tender but still hold together, having absorbed some gravy flavor without disintegrating.

08 GARNISH AND SERVE

Finish with a scatter of fresh coriander just before serving.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Adding the dumplings to the gravy too early, before they've steamed firm enough, or simmering them too long once added, causes them to break apart. Ensure they're fully steamed first, and simmer only gently in the gravy.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served hot with steamed rice or roti, a practical everyday meal especially when fresh vegetables are limited.
- A comforting, filling dish valued for its distinct texture within Bihari home cooking.

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How to serve, continued

Family Style

- A hearty vegetarian main dish alongside rice and a simple side, requiring minimal fresh produce.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Texture Right

- Steaming the dumplings until genuinely firm, not just set, is essential for them to hold up in the simmering gravy afterward.
- A firm, well-kneaded dough for the dumplings, similar to bread dough, produces the best final texture.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- The dumpling logs can be steamed, cooled, and sliced a day ahead, then simply added to fresh gravy when ready to serve.
- This dish is genuinely practical for keeping on hand as a pantry-based backup meal, requiring no fresh vegetables at all.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some cooks lightly pan-fry the sliced dumplings in a little oil before adding them to the gravy, giving them a slightly crisp edge that holds up particularly well during simmering.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

230 kcal	10 g	24 g	11 g	5 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Steamed Besan ki Sabzi	the classic version featured here, with steamed, sliced dumplings.
Fried Besan ki Sabzi	dumplings lightly pan-fried before being added to the gravy for extra texture.
Besan ki Sabzi with Yogurt	some households finish the gravy with a spoonful of yogurt for extra tang and creaminess.

Why did my dumplings fall apart in the gravy?

Likely undercooked at the steaming stage, or simmered too long once added to the gravy. Ensure they're firm all the way through before slicing, and simmer gently.

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Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Can I make this ahead for a busy week?

Yes — steamed and sliced dumplings keep well refrigerated for a day or two, ready to add to fresh gravy when needed.

Is this dish similar to any other Indian dish?

It's closely related to Rajasthan's gatte ki sabzi, another besan dumpling curry, though with its own distinct Bihari spicing and mustard oil base.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Besan	gram flour, the base ingredient for the dumplings in this dish.
Gatte ki Sabzi	a related Rajasthani besan dumpling curry, sharing a similar technique.
Ajwain	carom seeds, used in the dumpling dough for aroma.
Sorson Tel	Hindi for mustard oil, used throughout for its distinctive flavor.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Besan ki Sabzi

15m	30m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
4	Med
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

BESAN DUMPLINGS

Besan	180 g
Ajwain	1.5 g
Turmeric powder	1 g
Red chili powder	1 g
Mustard oil	30 ml
Salt	3 g
Water	45–60 ml

GRAVY

Mustard oil	45 ml
Cumin seeds	4 g
Onion	100 g
Ginger-garlic paste	15 g
Tomato	200 g
Turmeric powder	1.5 g
Coriander powder	3 g
Red chili powder	1.5 g
Water	480 ml
Salt	to taste
Fresh coriander	8 g

METHOD

01 **Make the dough.** Combine the besan, ajwain, turmeric, chili powder, mustard oil, and salt in a bowl.

02 **Shape into logs.** Divide the dough into 3–4 portions and roll each into a thin log, about ¾ inch / 2 cm thick.

03 **Steam until firm.** Steam the logs for 15–18 minutes, until firm and cooked through — test by inserting a knife, which should come out clean.

04 **Cool and slice.** Let the steamed logs cool for a few minutes, then slice into rounds or small pieces, about ½ inch / 1 cm thick.

05 **Sauté the onions.** Heat mustard oil in a kadai and add the cumin seeds, letting them sizzle.

06 **Add aromatics and tomato.** Stir in the ginger-garlic paste, cooking until fragrant, then add the tomato puree, turmeric, coriander powder, and chili powder.

07 **Add water and the dumplings.** Pour in the water and salt, bring to a simmer, then gently add the sliced dumplings.

08 **Garnish and serve.** Finish with a scatter of fresh coriander just before serving.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Besan	180 g	☐ Ajwain	1.5 g
☐ Turmeric powder	see recipe	☐ Red chili powder	see recipe
☐ Mustard oil	see recipe	☐ Salt	see recipe
☐ Cumin seeds	4 g	☐ Onion	100 g
☐ Ginger-garlic paste	15 g	☐ Tomato	200 g
☐ Coriander powder	3 g	☐ Fresh coriander	8 g

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